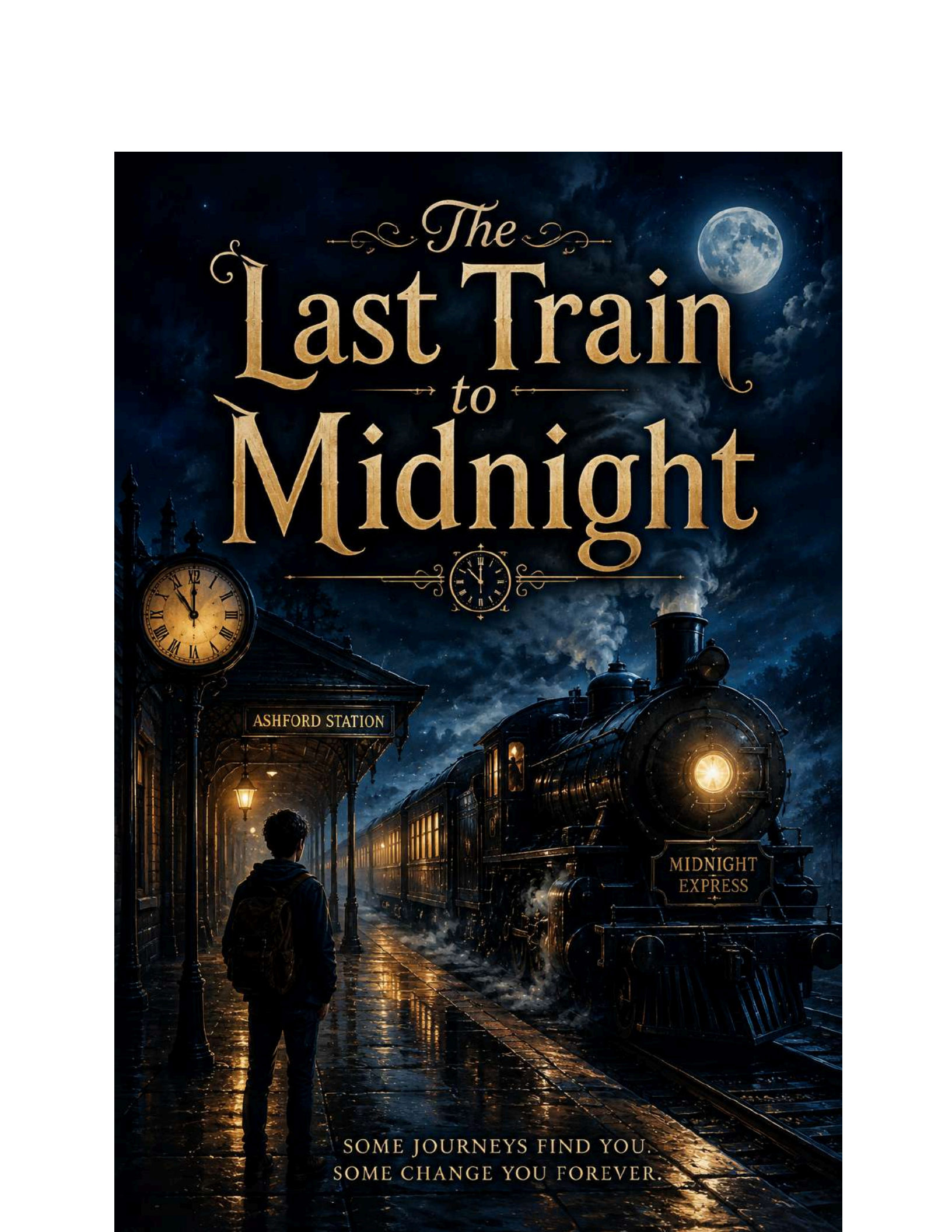


The background of the poster is a detailed illustration of a steam train at a station at night. A large, ornate steam locomotive, labeled 'MIDNIGHT EXPRESS' on its front, is pulling several passenger cars. The train is emitting a thick plume of white steam. To the left, a man with a backpack stands on a wet, reflective platform, looking towards the train. Above him is a large clock face showing the time as approximately 10:10. The station's roof is visible, with a sign that reads 'ASHFORD STATION'. The sky is dark and cloudy, with a full moon in the upper right corner. The title 'The Last Train to Midnight' is written in a large, elegant, golden font across the top. The overall mood is mysterious and nostalgic.

The Last Train *to* Midnight

SOME JOURNEYS FIND YOU.
SOME CHANGE YOU FOREVER.

The Last Train to Midnight

Seventeen-year-old Noah had missed the last bus home.

Rain poured from the sky as he stood alone at Ashford Station.

The station had closed years ago.

No trains stopped there anymore.

At least, that's what everyone said.



As thunder rolled overhead, Noah noticed a light in the distance.

At first, he thought it was a car.

But the light grew larger.

Brighter.

Soon he heard the sound of wheels on tracks.

A train was approaching.



Noah stared in disbelief.

The tracks had been abandoned for decades.

Yet the train slowly rolled into the station.

Its black metal body gleamed beneath the rain.

Above the door, a sign read:

MIDNIGHT EXPRESS



The doors opened with a hiss.

No passengers stepped off.

No conductor appeared.

The train simply waited.

As if expecting him.



Curiosity overcame fear.

Noah stepped aboard.

The doors immediately closed behind him.

The train began moving.



Inside, the train looked surprisingly modern.

Soft lamps illuminated rows of seats.

A grandfather clock ticked quietly at the end of the carriage.

Yet there wasn't a single passenger in sight.

Until Noah noticed a girl sitting near the window.



She looked about his age.

Dark hair.

Grey jacket.

A book resting on her lap.

When she noticed him, she smiled.

"You're new," she said.

Noah frowned.

"What do you mean?"

The girl closed her book.

"Most people don't find this train."



Before Noah could ask another question, the train entered a tunnel.

Darkness filled every window.

Then suddenly, the tunnel ended.

The view outside had completely changed.

The town was gone.

Instead, endless stars stretched across the horizon.

As if the train were traveling through space.



Passengers began appearing throughout the carriages.

An old sailor.

A scientist.

A violinist.

A pilot.

People from different times and places.

Each carried a suitcase.

Each looked lost.



The girl introduced herself as Emma.

She explained that the Midnight Express only appeared to people standing at important crossroads in their lives.

People unsure of where to go next.

People searching for purpose.

The train didn't take passengers to destinations.

It showed them possibilities.



At every stop, Noah saw a different version of his future.

One where he became an engineer.

One where he traveled the world.

One where he became a writer.

Another where he never took any risks at all.

Some futures looked exciting.

Others looked lonely.



Hours passed.

Or maybe only minutes.

Time seemed strange aboard the train.

Finally, the conductor appeared.

He wore a long black coat and carried a silver pocket watch.

"Your journey is ending," he said.



The train slowed.

Outside the window, Noah recognized Ashford Station.

The rain had stopped.

The sky was beginning to brighten.

Dawn was coming.



Before leaving, Noah turned to Emma.

"Will I ever see you again?"

She smiled.

"Only if you lose your way."

Then she disappeared.

As if she had never been there at all.



The doors opened.

Noah stepped onto the platform.

The train whistle echoed across the empty station.

Moments later, the Midnight Express vanished into the morning mist.

Leaving no tracks behind.



Noah never saw the train again.

But he no longer feared the future.

The Midnight Express had taught him something important.

There isn't just one path in life.

There are many.

And sometimes the hardest step is simply choosing one.

The End

